



SOUTH KOREA

Capital city: Seoul
Area: 38,023 sq miles (98,480 sq km)
Population: 47,700,000
Official language: Korean
Major religions: Christian 49%, Buddhist 47%, Confucianist 3%, other 1%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: South Korean won
Adult literacy rate: 98%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 714

SOUTH KOREA

LIKE NORTH KOREA, much of South Korea is mountainous and forested. Compared with its northern neighbor, however, it has a strong economy that trades with many other countries, such as Japan and the US. After becoming independent in 1948, South Korea was invaded by North Korea. By the end of the Korean War (1950–53), the cities and factories of South Korea were devastated and thousands of refugees had arrived in the country from the North. Within 20 years, a remarkable turnaround had taken place. New factories began to produce world-class products, and new cities sprang up. Today, South Korea has a well-educated workforce producing high-technology goods for export.



SEOUL

More than 21 million people live in and around the capital Seoul. Most of this modern city has been built in the decades since the end of the Korean War. As people have moved here from the countryside, the city has become crowded. To cope with this, Seoul has an excellent public transportation system, linking buses, trains, boats, and planes into one collective schedule.

Shipbuilding has expanded rapidly in South Korea, which is now the biggest and most successful shipbuilder in the world.

A Korean shaman is usually a woman, called a mundang.

People bring offerings of money and food to the mundang.



Burned offerings are made to pacify the spirits.

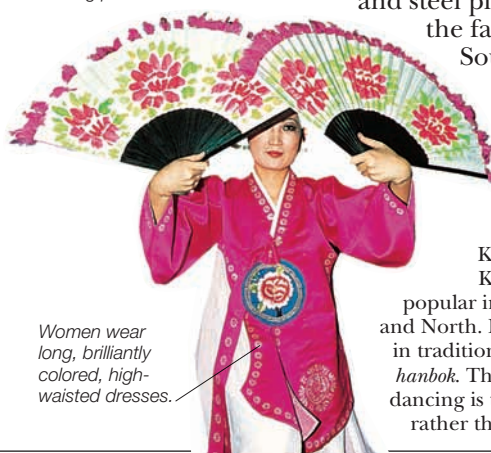
Aside from obtaining blessings from spirits, a mundang will try to cure people's diseases and help with personal problems.

SHAMANISM

People in South Korea belong to a number of religions. About half are Buddhists, the rest are Christian or Confucianist. Many people in rural areas still believe in shamanism – that an invisible spirit world lives alongside the visible human world. When the spirits interfere in the lives of humans, a shaman (priest) acts as a link between the two worlds.



The traditional Korean fan dance is performed by women only. As the women dance, they move faster and faster around each other while making patterns with their fans.



Women wear long, brilliantly colored, high-waisted dresses.

FARMING

Unlike North Korea, most farms in South Korea are small and family owned. Rice is the main crop, but barley, wheat, fruit, vegetables, and spices are also grown. Because much of the land is mountainous, farms can be found clustered along the river valleys and lowlands near the coast.

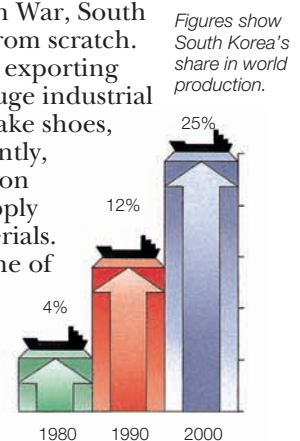


INDUSTRY

After the devastation of the Korean War, South Korea had to rebuild its industry from scratch. It concentrated on producing and exporting manufactured goods, setting up huge industrial companies, known as *chaebol*, to make shoes, clothes, ships, cars, and more recently, computers and video sets. Large iron and steel plants were built to supply the factories with raw materials.

South Korea now has one of the most successful economies in the world.

Ship production in South Korea



KOREAN DANCE

Korean dancing is popular in both the South and North. Dancers dress up in traditional clothes called *hanbok*. The goal of Korean dancing is to create a mood rather than to tell a story.

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